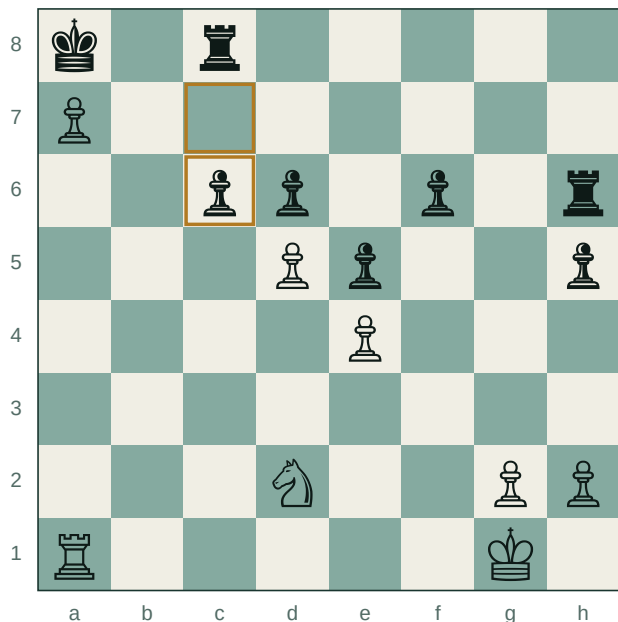


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 36

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 35...c6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

36. Nc4 Rhh8 37. Nb6+ Kb7 38. Nxc8

36.Nc4 The knight moves from d2 to c4. Recorded reply: **36...Rhh8**.

37.Nb6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From b6 it attacks king on a8 and rook on c8. Recorded reply: **37...Kb7**.

38.Nxc8 The knight captures the rook on c8.

At the end, nominal material is White 13 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -2 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on a8. Geometrically undefended: rook on c8 and rook on h6. Check for tactical protection.